1 Film

In this unit you will find out:

- how films use narrative devices, such as flashback, and camera techniques to convey meaning
- how audiences classify films by recognising their genre characteristics
- how institutions and organisations promote and regulate films
- how women are represented in films and film posters.

TALKING POINT

- Start off with an instant survey. First each person should write down their two favourite and two least favourite films.
- Now combine your chosen films into two class lists. Do the same types of films – such as adventure, fantasy, science fiction, romantic comedy and Westerns – appear on both lists? Were the same types of films popular with both boys and girls?



Genre

Did you find that it was easy to say what types of films your favourites were? If so, it is because you already know a lot about **genre**. You can also probably tell, from a few seconds of a TV trailer or even from a poster, what genre a new film is likely to be, and you will have certain expectations as a result. What film genre do these three words suggest: *Saloon*, *Sheriff*, *Gunfight*? You probably thought 'Western' before you even read the second word! Media producers rely on your ability to recognise genre when they promote new films, to arouse interest, expectation and anticipation.

ACTIVITY 1

1 Work in pairs. Make a table like the one below to show the characteristics of four popular genres: Romantic comedy, Disney animation, Science fiction and Horror.

Genre	Typical setting	Typical characters	Typical plots	Typical props	Typical themes
Romantic comedy		Young man, young woman	They meet, hate each other, coincidences throw them together ...		

2 Now share your answers with another pair. Add any good ideas that you missed.

In film, exploring the ways in which **genre characteristics** are used to create style and appeal is very important. Films are often a complex mix of genres – known as *cross-genres* or *hybrid genres* – to attract the widest possible target **audience**. For example,

KEY TERMS

Audience people who are consuming a media text

Genre a type of media text with certain predictable characteristics

Genre characteristics or **conventions** the typical features in a text which show the audience what genre it is

Toy Story (1995) seems to be a simple Disney animation aimed at children. However, it also uses the genre characteristics of:

- Science fiction – Buzz is a Space Ranger
- Westerns – Woody is a sheriff
- Adult comedy – the voices of Tom Hanks and Tim Allen deliver witty one-liners.

TIP

You can find out more about any of the films mentioned in this unit from Internet databases via Heinemann Hotlinks.

ACTIVITY 2

1 Look at the poster for *Mars Attacks!* (1996) in **1**. What genres are suggested in the poster?

2 Watch a range of film clips or film trailers. How soon can you identify what genre each one fits into, and if it demonstrates cross-genre (hybrid) characteristics? What audiences will each one attract?



1 Poster for *Mars Attacks!* (1996)

Science fiction

The roots of science fiction

Literary heritage

Science fiction is a genre that has at its heart some form of technology which is not yet possible, but which could be one day. Science fiction novels were popular long before film was even invented. Early sci-fi novels include *Twenty Thousand Leagues Under the Sea* by Jules Verne (1870) and *The Time Machine* (1895) by H G Wells.

Even earlier, Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* was published in 1818 when she was only 21. It was the first horror/science fiction story written by a woman. It told the story of a scientist who discovers how to make a dead man live again, with terrible consequences.

Early sci-fi films

With fantastic worlds, strange technology and almost magical events, sci-fi novels offered rich material for early film-makers. Some, such as *Frankenstein*, have been

made and re-made many times as film technology has developed and offered increasingly sophisticated and realistic effects.

If you asked a group of people to draw a representation of Frankenstein's monster everybody's images would probably be very similar. This is because they are familiar with the **film archetype** representation of the monster from the first ever Frankenstein film, made in 1933 with Boris Karloff playing the monster.



Boris Karloff as Frankenstein (1933)

The social symbol sci-fi

Because science-fiction narratives often include exploration, danger and new technology, they have been used to explore issues causing concern in society.

- The Frankenstein story was used in the 1933 film to explore the fear that men and women would become so taken up by factual scientific proof that they would stop believing in God.
- American sci-fi films in the 1950s and 1960s, such as *Dr Strangelove or: How I Learned To Stop Worrying And Love The Bomb* (1964), explored the fear that nuclear technology would result in the destruction of the world.
- *Invasion of the Bodysnatchers* (1956) seemed to be about an alien invasion, but was in fact about the McCarthy trials in the 1950s, when American citizens were questioned about their possible Communist sympathies.

ACTIVITY 3 EXTENSION

If you can watch *Invasion of the Bodysnatchers*, try to find out more about the McCarthy trials and then consider how the film relates to them.

The **blockbuster** sci-fi film

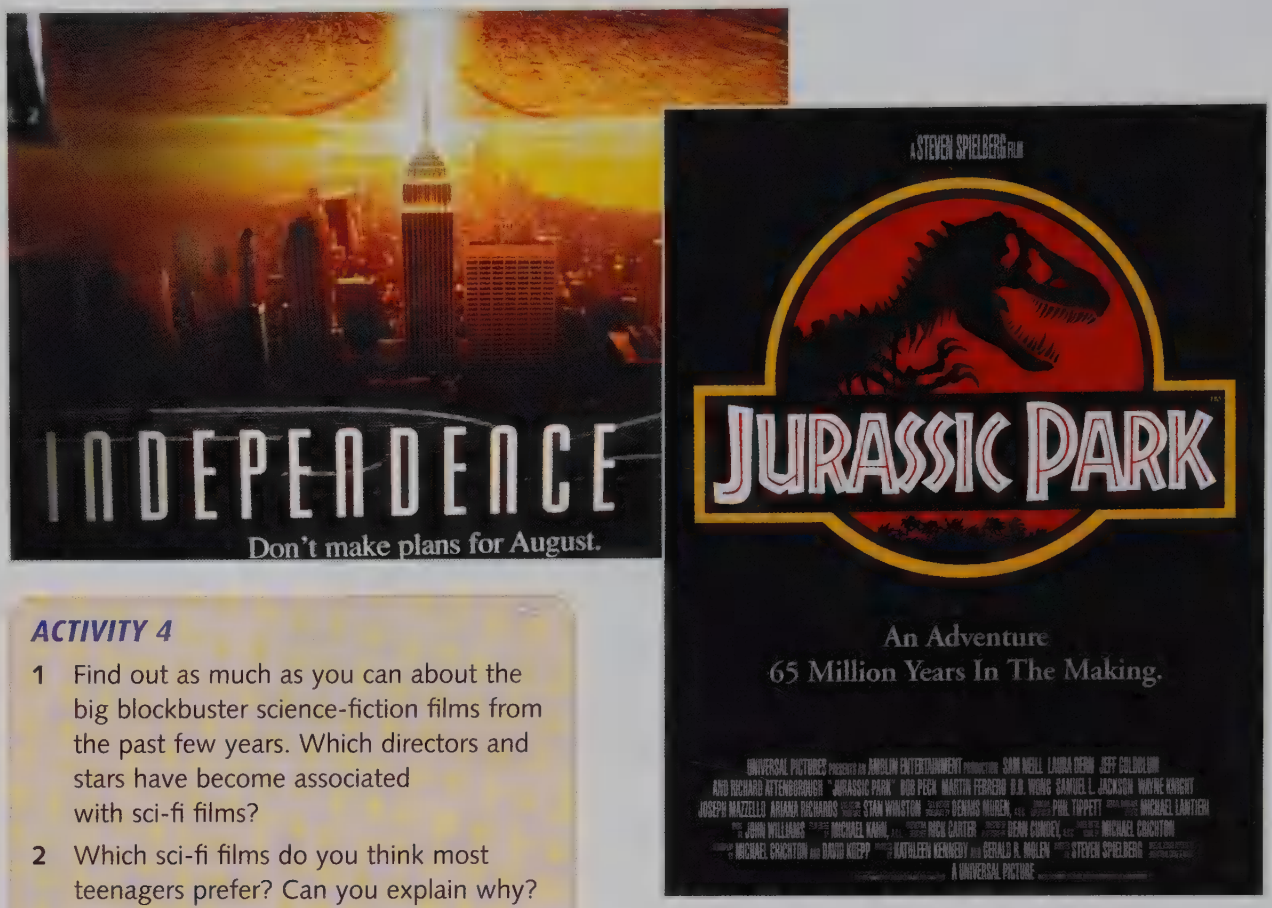
Until the early 1990s, sci-fi film was regarded as a minority genre which only longstanding fans watched. Then James Cameron produced special effects-driven *Terminator 2* in 1991, Steven Spielberg produced *Jurassic Park* in 1993 and Roland Emmerich wrote and directed *Stargate* in 1994. All these films were marketed to

KEY TERMS

Blockbuster a film expected to be a hit, so-called because of the long queues around the block to see successful films

Film archetype the outstanding features of a character, which other film-makers imitate in later films, e.g. Sean Connery as James Bond saying: 'The name's Bond. James Bond'

audiences as cross-genres of action with science fiction. With a big budget and special effects, Emmerich followed *Stargate* up in 1996 with *Independence Day*, and science fiction was established as a hugely exciting and action-packed genre for teenagers (3).



Sci-fi films became big hits in the 1990s

ACTIVITY 4

1 Find out as much as you can about the big blockbuster science-fiction films from the past few years. Which directors and stars have become associated with sci-fi films?

2 Which sci-fi films do you think most teenagers prefer? Can you explain why? Try to decide what the ingredients are that make a sci-fi film really popular.

Representations in science fiction

Representation is an important word in media studies. It means the ways in which people, places or events are *re–presented* to audiences. Representations of people are usually designed to make them as believable as possible, but if you look closely at representations of key social groups such as women, men, teenagers, ethnic groups, old people, etc. you will see that they are often quite **stereotypical**. Many teenage representations show them as being disrespectful, moody and selfish – this is obviously a very narrow view of teenagers.

ACTIVITY 5

1 Look at a range of film clips in several genres. Try to identify different ways that people are represented.

2 Make a list to show how similar social groups (women, men, teenagers, ethnic groups, old people) are generally represented.

3 Try to suggest examples of representations that are *not* stereotypical but seem to be genuinely convincing and 'realistic'.

KEY TERMS

Representation how people, places or events are represented or portrayed to audiences in media texts

Stereotypical showing groups of people in terms of certain shared and expected characteristics, e.g. showing women as nagging housewives

Propp suggested in the 1920s that every story had characters in certain roles: hero, heroine or princess, villain, donor or mentor and helper (see page 101 to find out more about these roles). Science fiction can represent groups of people in unusual ways by allowing them to fulfil unexpected roles in societies that are wholly invented.

Representations of women

Sci-fi has offered women real opportunities to be empowered and to break away from the more helpless 'princess' role. Ripley in Ridley Scott's *Alien* (1979) and Sarah Connor in *Terminator* (1984) were given lead roles who had real power and strength and were often responsible for pushing the **narrative** forward. It could be argued that such women play the hero role rather than the heroine.

ACTIVITY 6

In small groups, find out about some or all of these characters. Present your findings as a display of images with accompanying factfiles.

- Lara Croft in *Tomb Raider* (2001)
- Ripley in *Alien Resurrection* (1997)
- Princess Amidala in *Star Wars I* and *II* (1999 and 2002)
- Sarah Connor in *Terminator 2* (1991)
- Lyndsay in *The Abyss* (1989)
- Trinity in *Matrix* (1999)

Representations of aliens

One of the great conventions of sci-fi is the presence of some amazingly memorable aliens! Try jotting down as many as you can in one minute.

Sometimes taking 'human' form, sometimes robot, sometimes imaginative life-forms from other planets, aliens allow film-makers to explore different patterns of behaviour, language and customs. The essential thing about aliens is that they are *different* from us.

It is not hard to see that aliens are often used as a symbol for themes of belonging and being different. They can also be a way for film-makers to explore social problems, such as prejudice, in a subtle way.

ACTIVITY 7

1. Create your own alien. You can make it friendly or hostile, but you must label your design by pointing out key features that make it different from a human.
2. Extend your design by writing a paragraph describing how the alien responds to humans, and what would happen if it came to Earth.

ACTIVITY 8 EXTENSION

Other frequent representations in sci-fi films are: *scientists*, **stock characters** and *captains* or other leadership figures. Choose one of these representations and analyse their roles in one or two films of your choice, sharing your findings with the class as a presentation or display.

KEY TERMS

Narrative a story or account

Stock character supporting character who is often quite stereotypical and whose job it is to help the lead characters, to be saved by them or to die

Reading science-fiction films

Reading a film is similar to reading a book. First you must know the language, and then be able to work out what it means. Use this checklist to help you to look for the most important features in a sci-fi film:

- *Characters* (including aliens) will have clear roles and purposes in the narrative.
- *Costumes* are important – especially in future worlds.
- *Settings* are part of the created world and often involve **special effects**.
- *Colours* are important and are often symbolic, e.g. neon green often symbolises 'the alien'.
- *Soundtrack* is a vital clue to suggesting mood, theme and key moments.
- *Conventions* such as space, jargon, gadgets, weapons, etc. all build up the understanding of the narrative.
- *Special effects* may play a huge part – look out for animation, CGI (computer-generated imagery – see page 111), clever use of camera angles, action sequences.

KEY TERM

Special effects
exciting and dynamic visual or sound effects used to create impact in films

ACTIVITY 9

Practise your reading skills in science fiction. Watch clips from a range of sci-fi films. Make notes on the conventions, themes and characters as you go. Write your notes up as an essay or report.

ACTIVITY 10 EXTENSION

Prepare a more developed film brief (proposal), based around the following idea:

An exploration spaceship has gone missing without warning, and a crew must be sent to rescue them. Led by a female Captain and a male First Officer, the rescue ship is captured by an alien ship and taken to a new world where the inhabitants have very strange customs. The original exploration crew are also there, and the humans must work out a plan to escape and get back to Earth – but not without tragedy, love and an unexpected twist of fate before the end of the film.

1. Give your film a title and explain its meaning.
2. Cast the main parts and explain your choices.
3. Outline the narrative more fully, explaining all the interesting details.
4. Design the film poster.
5. If you are going to develop this work into a coursework piece, plan the promotion campaign for the film. This could include: storyboard or trailer, merchandise designs, soundtrack CD cover and DVD cover.



TIP

Keep your work from Activity 10 in your coursework folder.